

Cut the number of choices you make each day. Your brain will thank you

By Associated Press, adapted by Newsela staff on 08.24.26

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Drowning in options? Reducing the number of decisions you make each day can boost your focus and peace of mind. Illustration: Peter Hamlin/AP

The perfect shirt. The movie to watch tonight. Your best friend. There are all kinds of choices that people make every day.

Scientists have done hundreds of studies on choices. This research shows having too many options is not a good thing. More choices can stress people and leave them unable to decide. It can also make people less happy with their choices, said Barry Schwartz. He used to teach psychology.

To make things easier for your mind, he said, limit the number of choices you make. Your brain will thank you.

More Is Often More Confusing

Schwartz gave a few examples of studies about decision-making.

Many companies offer plans to help workers save money for the future. One popular plan is a 401(k). But researchers found that when a company offers many plans, fewer workers sign up.

Less important choices showed similar patterns. One study looked at how grocery choices affected shoppers. It found people bought more jars of jam when they had six choices instead of 24. In another study, students were more likely to finish an extra-credit assignment when they had six topics. Fewer students wanted the extra credit when they had to choose from 30 topics.

Schwartz said that too many choices can make people feel stuck.

People might also make poorer decisions. That's because more options increase the chances of bad outcomes. Even if they make a good choice, they might worry there was a better one.

Not all people are like this all the time, Schwartz added. Car enthusiasts love car details. They will happily review the information for every car when buying a new one.

"But you don't feel that way when it comes to buying jam," he said.

The Brain Doesn't Like Making Decisions

Daniel Willingham is also a psychology professor. He said the brain actually tries to stop us from thinking too much.

Solving problems uses more energy than remembering things. This idea comes from how humans survived long ago. When we have a goal, the brain first remembers what worked before. This came from our ancestors reacting to danger or finding a place to stay. It only starts solving problems if it has to.

"Another way to put it is that if you're thinking, things are not going well," Willingham said.

This is why people often do things without thinking much. They could try something new, like taking a different way to work. But they usually don't.

Schwartz said the problem of having too many choices is also part of our daily lives. Social media makes it worse. Online, everyone can easily compare their choices to others.

If you have two options for jeans, "nobody expects the jeans they buy to fit perfectly," Schwartz said. "When there are 2,000 options... Now, you do expect your jeans to fit perfectly."

Limit Your Choices And Move On

David Epstein used to be a maximalist. Now he limits his opportunities to make choices. Once, he bought 10 of the same well-fitting T-shirts in different colors.

He followed Herbert Simon's example. Simon was a famous thinker. He only had three sets of clothes and ate almost the same thing every day. Simon created the word "satisficing," which means picking something that is good enough and then moving on.

Epstein sets satisficing rules for himself when shopping online. He thinks about why he is buying something and doesn't read reviews.

Willingham and Schwartz suggest looking to people in your life to help, too. If you need a new phone, ask a friend who likes theirs.

Changing how you make choices is hard, but it helps. "Over time ... you find it easier to make decisions," Schwartz said. "You end up more satisfied with the decisions you make." And, he added, you get more free time.

Write Prompt

Write a summary of the text. Include the most important details from the article.

Quiz

- 1 Read the section "The Brain Doesn't Like Making Decisions." Which sentence explains why people repeat familiar actions instead of trying something new?
- (A) Daniel Willingham is also a psychology professor.
 - (B) Solving problems uses more energy than remembering things.
 - (C) Online, everyone can easily compare their choices to others.
 - (D) "When there are 2,000 options... Now, you do expect your jeans to fit perfectly."
- 2 Which sentence from the article helps the reader understand that having fewer choices can make people's lives better?
- (A) Scientists have done hundreds of studies on choices.
 - (B) They will happily review the information for every car when buying a new one.
 - (C) This came from our ancestors reacting to danger or finding a place to stay.
 - (D) "You end up more satisfied with the decisions you make."
- 3 What is the main idea of the article?
- (A) Fewer workers sign up for savings plans when companies offer many different plans.
 - (B) Social media allows people to compare their choices with other people's choices.
 - (C) People make better decisions when they spend time comparing many different options.
 - (D) Limiting choices can make decisions easier and help people feel better about their choices.
- 4 Which sentence summarizes the section "More Is Often More Confusing"?
- (A) Companies offer workers savings plans to help them prepare for the future.
 - (B) Car enthusiasts may enjoy studying every option before deciding which car to buy.
 - (C) Having many options can make choosing harder and leave people unhappy with their decisions.
 - (D) A study about grocery choices found that people bought more jam when they had fewer choices.

Answer Key

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